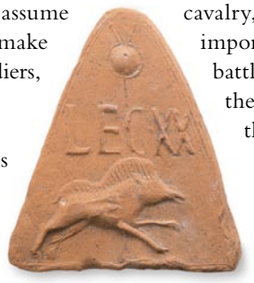


Ruling by the sword
Roman rule offered conquered peoples peace and security, but in the end, it was the might of the legions that held the Empire together. The carved frieze *(above)* from the 3rd century CE shows a Roman army slaughtering a group of Germans. The legionary's main weapon was the short sword or *gladius*. The blade and scabbard *(right)*, found in the Rhine at Mainz, date from the 1st century CE.

AT ITS PEAK THE ROMAN ARMY was probably the most effective fighting force in the Ancient World. It conquered and maintained an empire that, by the 1st century CE, stretched from Britain to North Africa and from Spain to Egypt. At the heart of this formidable organization were the legionaries – tough professional infantry equipped with sword, shield, and javelin. Equally dominant in pitched battles and in siege warfare, they were used to cow or destroy the enemies of Rome in campaigns of ruthless efficiency.

The Roman army was originally a militia of part-time soldiers, with every propertied citizen owing periods of military service to the state. Around 300 BCE the legions began to assume the form and organization that would make them such an invincible force. The soldiers, although still not professionals, were extremely successful in combat, most notably in defeating the Carthaginians in the Punic Wars. But as victorious campaigns extended Roman rule over an ever wider area, part-time service became inadequate to Rome's military needs. Ordinary citizens could not be expected to engage in prolonged campaigns far from home or man permanent garrisons in distant provinces. By the time Julius Caesar was engaged upon his famous conquest of the Gauls (58–51 BCE), the Roman army had evolved into a permanent force of professional soldiers.



Legionary emblem
This tile is embossed with a leaping boar, emblem of the 20th Legion, based in Chester.

LEGIONARIES AND AUXILIARIES

The professionalization of the army was not without its drawbacks. Regular soldiers tended to develop an allegiance to the commander who led them rather than to the state, and Rome was for a time torn apart by civil wars between rival generals. But after Augustus established himself as Rome's first emperor (from 31 BCE to 14 CE), the regular army became the rock on which the Roman Empire stood. This army included auxiliary cohorts that would be recruited from various "barbarian" peoples who did not have the privilege of Roman citizenship. It also included cavalry, usually auxiliaries, who formed an important element of the army on the battlefield. But there is no question that the heart and soul of the army was the Roman citizen foot soldier.

The legionary, upon whom the burden of maintaining the Roman Empire at its apogee rested, was an infantryman trained to fight in close formation with short sword and javelin. Although conscription was not unknown at times of military crisis, he was generally a volunteer and in principle had to fulfil certain criteria. Firstly, he had to be a citizen. This did not mean he had to be born in the city of Rome, but in the early days of the Empire it did mean that he was probably at least from Italy. By 212 CE, however, citizenship had been extended to all free men across the Empire. Slaves were rigorously excluded from the ranks of the legions and any who had enlisted by falsely claiming to be free men could expect severe punishment if their deception was discovered. Men convicted of serious crimes or facing prosecution were also barred. Every potential recruit was subjected to a physical examination and some were rejected as too short of stature or as unfit for service on medical grounds.



GLADIUS AND SCABBARD